Premenstrual Dysphoric Disorder (PMDD)

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Microbiome Signatures, Microbiome Medicine

Abstract. Premenstrual Dysphoric Disorder (PMDD), symptoms, causes, and new microbiome-focused treatments for better management

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Overview

Premenstrual Dysphoric Disorder (PMDD) affects roughly 3–9% of women of reproductive age and manifests as severe mood, behavioral, and physical symptoms tightly linked to the luteal phase of the menstrual cycle, distinguishing it from milder premenstrual syndrome (PMS).[1][2] Central to PMDD's pathophysiology is an altered sensitivity of the central nervous system to normal fluctuations of ovarian hormones, particularly progesterone and its metabolite allopregnanolone, which modulate GABAergic and serotonergic neurotransmission and contribute to mood dysregulation.[3][4] Neuroimaging studies show abnormal activation of prefrontal brain regions and cerebellum, correlating with symptom severity.[5] Disruptions in biological rhythms, such as reduced nocturnal melatonin and elevated core body temperature, further exacerbate symptoms.[6] Although direct investigation of the microbiome in PMDD is sparse across these sources, emerging evidence highlights the gut-brain axis's role in mood and hormonal regulation, suggesting that microbial metabolites may influence neurotransmitter systems and inflammation implicated in PMDD.[7] This microbiome-brain interaction remains a promising but underexplored area for understanding PMDD's etiology and developing novel therapies. Clinically, effective treatment strategies include selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors administered during the luteal phase or symptom onset, hormonal interventions, and cognitive behavioral therapy, with a growing emphasis on individualized, multidisciplinary approaches.[8][9]

Diagnosis

The diagnosis of PMDD predominantly relies on prospective symptom tracking aligned with DSM-5 criteria, emphasizing the cyclical nature of emotional, behavioral, and physical symptoms occurring in the luteal phase and remitting shortly after menstruation begins.[10][11] Tools such as the Premenstrual Symptoms Screening Tool for Adolescents (PSST-A) and daily symptom diaries are commonly used for clinical assessment and research validation.[12] Emerging non-invasive diagnostic approaches including microbiome, metabolomic, and metallomic signatures remain underexplored but show promising potential. Although the microbiome's role in modulating neuroendocrine and inflammatory pathways implicated in PMDD has been suggested, specific microbial or metabolite markers for diagnostic use have yet to be validated. Current research highlights the need for integrative biomarkers combining symptomatology with

biological signatures to enhance early, objective diagnosis and personalize treatment strategies.[13] Future investigations focusing on gut-brain axis modulation, hormonal metabolomics, and trace metal profiling could provide novel, non-invasive tools that complement traditional clinical assessments, improving diagnostic precision and patient outcomes.

Causal Theories

PMDD arises from a multifaceted interplay of neurobiological, hormonal, genetic, and environmental factors. Central to its pathogenesis is an abnormal sensitivity to neurosteroids, particularly progesterone and its metabolite allopregnanolone, which modulate GABA_A receptor activity and affect mood regulation, although receptor expression varies and evidence remains indirect with limited sample sizes.[14] [15] Serotonergic dysregulation also contributes to PMDD symptoms, but biomarker replication is inconsistent, and overlap with depressive disorders complicates interpretations.[16] Disruptions in circadian rhythms, including altered melatonin secretion and core body temperature, have been observed, though causal links remain unclear due to mixed findings.[17] Genetic predispositions involving polymorphisms in hormone receptor and neurotransmitter genes suggest a heritable component, yet the polygenic and complex nature of PMDD challenges isolation of specific causal variants.[18] Emerging research highlights the gut-brain axis and microbiome as potential modulators of neuroinflammation and hormonal metabolism, proposing new pathways influencing PMDD pathophysiology, but clinical validation remains preliminary.[19]

Associated Conditions

PMDD is frequently associated with a spectrum of psychiatric, neurological, and physical conditions that often exacerbate its clinical presentation and complicate management. Psychiatric comorbidities are prominent, with high rates of co-occurrence reported for major depressive disorder, generalized anxiety disorder, panic disorder, and particularly bipolar disorder, which shares cyclic mood fluctuations and neurobiological vulnerabilities with PMDD.[20] Women with bipolar disorder show an increased prevalence of PMDD, which is linked to greater symptom severity, earlier illness onset, and more frequent mood episodes. Additionally, PMDD often coexists with other mood and anxiety spectrum disorders, including post-traumatic stress disorder, which may reflect overlapping dysregulation of neuroendocrine and neurotransmitter systems such as serotonin and GABA.[21][22]` Neurological conditions like migraine are commonly exacerbated premenstrually, and inflammatory disorders such as fibromyalgia and autoimmune diseases show symptom patterns aligned with the menstrual cycle, suggesting shared neuroimmune and hormonal pathways.[23] Furthermore, PMDD overlaps with eating disorders like bulimia nervosa and binge eating disorder, likely due to hormonal modulation of appetite and reward systems.[24] Metabolic and endocrine conditions, including thyroid dysfunction, hyperprolactinemia, and anemia, may mimic or worsen PMDD symptoms, necessitating careful differential diagnosis.[25] Lifestyle factors such as smoking, obesity, and high stress levels further contribute to symptom severity.

Primer

Unlike typical PMS, PMDD involves heightened sensitivity of the central nervous system to normal fluctuations in ovarian hormones, especially progesterone and its neuroactive metabolite allopregnanolone, which modulate key neurotransmitter systems such as GABA and serotonin.[26] This neuro-hormonal

interplay underlies the cyclical pattern of symptoms and distinguishes PMDD as a distinct neuropsychiatric condition. Emerging evidence highlights the role of major microbial associations (MMAs) within the gut microbiome, which may influence PMDD by modulating neuroinflammation, hormonal metabolism, and neurotransmitter synthesis through the gut-brain axis.[27] These findings support the potential for microbiome-targeted interventions (MBTIs) aimed at restoring microbial balance to alleviate symptoms. Additionally, metallomic factors, such as trace metal imbalances, could affect neurochemical pathways involved in PMDD, although research in this area is still developing. Understanding these core concepts, hormonal neurosteroid sensitivity, neurotransmitter dysregulation, microbiome interactions including major microbial associations, and potential metallomic influences, is essential to grasp the complex etiology of PMDD and its emerging biomarkers, paving the way for innovative, personalized diagnostic and treatment strategies.

Metallomic Signatures

Current evidence on the metallomic signature in PMDD is limited but suggests that heavy metals and trace elements may influence symptom severity and pathophysiology. Smoking, which introduces heavy metals such as cadmium and lead, is significantly associated with increased risk and severity of PMDD, possibly through neuroendocrine and inflammatory pathways that disrupt hormonal and neurotransmitter balance.[28][29] Dysregulation of the hypothalamic-pituitary-adrenal (HPA) axis seen in PMS/PMDD patients may be exacerbated by toxic metal exposure, compounding stress response impairments. While direct studies on metallomic profiling in PMDD are scarce, parallels from neuropsychiatric and endocrine disorders suggest that alterations in metals like zinc, copper, and magnesium could affect neurotransmission and neuroinflammation, contributing to symptom expression. Understanding these metallomic influences could inform non-invasive biomarker development and novel intervention strategies, including detoxification and nutritional supplementation, to mitigate symptom burden. Further focused metallomic research in PMDD populations is critical to clarify these associations and support targeted clinical applications.

Major Microbial Associations

Recent research indicates significant alterations in the gut microbiota composition in women experiencing PMDD and related premenstrual symptoms. Notably, studies have shown that certain beneficial butyrate-producing bacteria, such as *Butyricicoccus* and *Megasphaera*, are decreased in PMDD, potentially reducing short-chain fatty acid production important for neuroprotection and anti-inflammatory effects. Likewise, *Parabacteroides*, known for producing GABA and modulating brain neurotransmission, is diminished, possibly contributing to impaired GABAergic function implicated in PMDD pathology.[30] These microbial shifts reflect disruptions in neuroimmune and metabolic pathways via the gut-brain axis, suggesting that targeted microbiome interventions could ameliorate PMDD symptoms.

Microbe	Status in PMDD	Role/Impact
Butyricicoccus	Decreased	Butyrate producer; supports neuroprotection and anti-inflammation.
Megasphaera	Decreased	Produces butyrate; influences brain-derived neurotrophic factor (BDNF).
Parabacteroides	Decreased	GABA producer; modulates neurotransmission, anti-inflammatory effects.
Anaerotaenia	Increased	Positively correlated with symptom severity; role unclear.

Interventions

PMDD treatments include pharmacological, nutraceutical, complementary, and microbiome-targeted interventions (MBTIs). SSRIs mainly affect serotonin without directly targeting the microbiome. Probiotics, exercise, and SCFA supplements show promise by restoring gut balance and influencing brain function. Fecal microbiota transplantation (FMT) remains under investigation as a potential therapy to restore a healthy gut microbiome and help alleviate mood and physical symptoms associated with PMDD. Herbal and nutraceutical options like saffron and S-equol provide antioxidant and hormone-modulating benefits, with S-equol's efficacy partly reliant on gut microbiota metabolism. Emerging neuroactive steroid modulators and acupuncture work through neuroendocrine pathways but don't directly target the microbiome. These varied approaches reflect PMDD's complex nature and the growing role of microbiome-focused treatments.

Interventions	Mechanisms of Action	MBTI Status
Probiotics	Modulate gut microbial diversity and metabolite production; reduce pro-inflammatory cytokines; enhance immunological tolerance; influence HPA axis and neurotransmitter synthesis (GABA, serotonin); improve mood regulation via gut-brain axis.[31][32]	Validated
SCFA Supplementation	Restore gut microbial metabolite balance; enhance gut barrier; reduce systemic inflammation; modulate microglial activation; influence neurotransmitter pathways and neuroimmune signaling, improving mood and cognition.[33] [34]	Under Investigation
Dietary Interventions (Traditional South China Diet (TSCD), Mediterranean diet, micronutrient supplementation)	Promote balanced nutrient intake that supports neurotransmitter synthesis and hormonal regulation; influence gut microbiota composition via increased fiber, vegetables, and antioxidants; reduce systemic inflammation and oxidative stress; modulate serotonin pathways through carbohydrate quality; inverse association with PMD symptom severity.[35][36]	Promising Candidate
Fecal Microbiota Transplantation (FMT)	Restore healthy gut microbial composition; reestablish microbial diversity; modulate immune and neuroinflammatory pathways; influence gut-brain communication via neurotransmitter and metabolite production, potentially reducing mood symptoms and improving neuroendocrine regulation.[37][x]	Experimental
Exercise	Modulates gut microbiota diversity and increases SCFA-producing bacteria; reduces systemic inflammation; improves HPA axis regulation; enhances neuroplasticity and mood via BDNF upregulation; indirectly supports microbiome-brain axis.[38]	Promising Candidate

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